

The defending champion Odisha Warriors no longer exists. The spotlight will be firmly on the newly inducted Ranchi side, with junior India women's coach Tushar Khandker and former senior India women's coach Harendra Singh (**pic, right**) leading its men's and women's teams respectively. With both under scrutiny, it remains to be seen whether the franchise persists with them and how any changes might affect players, particularly the women.

Uncertainty over the availability of several European players also continues, with their team managements insisting on prioritising the World Cup and the Pro League. Amid all this, the federation will be hoping the focus shifts decisively back to the turf once the league begins.

The teams would be hoping for the same. Unlike last year, most franchises and Hockey India itself began public outreach and marketing initiatives well in advance, especially on social media, to generate interest. The decision to move the men's event from a single venue in Rourkela to three cities, Chennai, Ranchi and Bhubaneswar, is also expected to combat the fatigue and monotony players



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complained of last year, while widening the league's reach.

The mini-auction in September helped teams refine their compositions and strategies. Players were traded, and the reduced squad size, from 24 to 20, allowed franchises to spend slightly more on individuals. Across both men's and women's teams, juniors took centre stage, Indian and overseas alike, with

franchises focusing on retaining domestic talent while investing heavily in new foreign signings. There were comebacks too, such as Monika, who went unsold last year but emerged as the most expensive buy this time.

The HIL, too, will be hoping for an equally impressive comeback, both for its own future and for Indian hockey's larger cause.

TEAMS (men)

Shrachi Bengal Tigers: The defending champion has retained the core of its youth brigade, with Jugraj Singh and Abhishek expected to provide the goals. It has also brought in and traded for big overseas names, including German duo Christopher Ruhr and Tom Grambusch, to add experience and leadership.

HIL Governing Council: Taking over from the UP Rudras, the players will be free of performance pressure from private owners but will be keen to prove they are good enough even without one. Strong on Indian juniors and overseas attackers, the team could go all the

way if everything clicks, but may struggle if its foreign players fail to fire.

Hyderabad Toofans: Having retained its entire squad, the team will hope continuity in personnel and support staff helps it go one better than last year's runner-up finish.

JSW Soorma HC: The franchise has also retained 19 of its 20 players, placing faith in a tried-and-tested group.

Ranchi Royals: New entrant to the league but with a largely familiar core from Team Gonasika, it will hope its midfield- and attack-heavy line-up compensates for relative inexperience in defence.

Delhi SG Pipers: Realistically aiming to rise above last year's bottom-place finish, the side will rely heavily on its four Penalty Corner specialists for goals.

Tamil Nadu Dragons: Underdog which lacked marquee names but finished fourth on the back of consistent performances, it will look to repeat that feat with a defence-first approach.

Vedanta Kalinga Lancers: Armed with the largest purse at the auction, it invested heavily in Australian youngsters Liam Henderson and Cooper Burns, and will hope its formidable midfield-attack combination delivers.